Ink of Sinai

Read Biblical Hebrew in 22 Days.

A few minutes a day.
Every word straight from the Torah.



“light”

You’ll read this word today.

How it works.

Most days add a new letter, then a real word from the Torah that uses only what you already know.

Hebrew reads right to left. Start every word on the right.

The dots and lines under and over the letters are the vowels. They tell you how to say it.

Under each word you'll see its sounds, piece by piece. Cover them, read, then check.

Missed a day? Don't restart. Reread the last word you finished, then turn the page.

Every word is copied from the Leningrad Codex, a complete Hebrew Bible from around AD 1008. Letter sounds follow modern Israeli pronunciation.

Next page *Day 1. Your first word.*

א

Aleph

Silent. It holds a place for a vowel.

וֹ

Vav

With a dot on top, it says **o**, as in *go*.

ר

Resh

r, as in *rain*.

Read it

אוֹר

אוֹ ר

o r *start ←*

“light” *Genesis 1:3*

You just read your first Hebrew word.

The first words God speaks in the Bible are “Let there be light.” This is the last word of that line.

Day 1 done. Tick box 1.

The 22 letters *read right to left*

ו **Vav** *v · o · u*	ה **He** *h*	ד **Dalet** *d*	ג **Gimel** *g*	בּ ב **Bet** *b · v*	א **Aleph** *silent*
ל **Lamed** *l*	כּ כ ך **Kaf** *k · kh*	י **Yod** *y*	ט **Tet** *t*	ח **Het** *kh*	ז **Zayin** *z*
צ ץ **Tsadi** *ts*	פּ פ ף **Pe** *p · f*	ע **Ayin** *silent*	ס **Samekh** *s*	נ ן **Nun** *n*	מ ם **Mem** *m*
		ת **Tav** *t*	שׁ שׂ **Shin · Sin** *sh · s*	ר **Resh** *r*	ק **Qof** *k*

The vowels *shown on ב and א*

בָ בַ **a** *as in father*	בֵ בֶ **e** *as in bed*	בִ **i** *as in ski*	בֹ בוֹ **o** *as in go*
בֻ בוּ **u** *as in flute*	בְ **quick e, or silent**	אֲ **short a**	

Your 22 days *tick one a day*

1	*2*	*3*	*4*	*5*	*6*	*7*	*8*	*9*	*10*	*11*
12	*13*	*14*	*15*	*16*	*17*	*18*	*19*	*20*	*21*	*22*

בּ ב

Bet

With a dot: **b**, as in *Bible*.
Without it: **v**, as in *vine*.

בָּ A small T under a letter: **a**, as in *father*.

Read it

בָּרָא

א ָ בָּ

silent ra ba *start ←*

“he created” *Genesis 1:1*

“In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth.” This is the word “created.”

Tomorrow *One letter turns “light” into “the light.”*



He

h, as in *hat*.



At the front of a word, הָ often means **the**.

ה ח

He ה has a gap at the top left. Het ח, on day 13, is closed.

Read it

הָאוֹר



r o ha *start ←*

“the light” *Genesis 1:4*

God sees the light, that it is good, and separates it from the darkness.

י Yod

y, as in *yes*. The smallest letter.

יְ Two dots stacked: a quick **e** at the start of a word.

הִ One dot underneath: **i**, as in *ski*. A י right after it is silent.

Read it

יְהִי אוֹר׃

יְ הִ אוֹ ר

ye hi o r

“let there be light” *Genesis 1:3*

Two words in Hebrew. It takes four in English.

Tomorrow *The name for the first five books of the Bible.*



Tav

t, as in *time*.

תּ

A dot inside a letter does not change its sound. Bet בּ is an exception, and you'll meet a few more.

הָ

A ה at the end of a word, with no vowel, is silent.

ת ח

Tav ת has a small foot at the bottom left. Het ח, on day 13, does not.

Read it

תּוֹרָה

ה	רָ	תּוֹ
silent	ra	to

"Torah, teaching" *Deuteronomy 33:4*

"Moses commanded us a Torah, an inheritance for the community of Jacob." The word means teaching.

Tomorrow *The first word of the Bible.*



Shin · Sin

Dot on the right: **sh**, as in *shoe*. Dot on the left: **s**, as in *sun*.



Two dots side by side: **e**, as in *bed*. The א after it has no vowel, so it is silent.



At the front of a word, בְּ often means **in**.

Read it

בְּרֵאשִׁית



t shi re be

“in the beginning” *Genesis 1:1*

The first word of the Bible. You can read it now.

ט Tet

t, as in *time*. The same sound as Tav ת.

Read it

טוֹב

ב	טוֹ
v	to

“good” *Genesis 1:4*

Seven times in Genesis 1, God sees that what he made is good.

Review: read these without the sound row

אוֹר · בָּרָא · הָאוֹר ·

יְהִי אוֹר · תּוֹרָה · בְּרֵאשִׁית

Tomorrow *The heavens.*

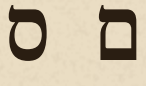


Mem

m, as in *mother*. At the end of a word it closes into a square: ם.



A short line under a letter also says **a**. At the front of a word, הַ also means **the**.



Final Mem ם is square. Samekh ס, on day 20, is round.

Read it

הַשָּׁמַיִם



m yi ma sha ha

“the heavens” *Genesis 1:1*

“In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth.” You have now read three of its words.

Tomorrow *How God sees all of creation at the end.*

ד Dalet

d, as in *door*.

אֹ A dot on top, at the left: also **o**.

ד ר Dalet ד has a sharp corner. Resh ר is round.

Read it

טוֹב מְאֹד

טוֹ ב מְ אֹ ד

to v me o d

“very good” *Genesis 1:31*

God looks at everything he has made, and it is very good.

Tomorrow *The last word of the priestly blessing.*



Lamed

l, as in *lamp*. The tallest letter: it rises above the line.

Read it

שָׁלוֹם

שָׁ לוֹ ם

sha lo m

“peace” *Numbers 6:26*

The blessing the priests speak over Israel ends with this word: “…and give you peace.”



Ayin

Silent, like Aleph. It holds a place for a vowel.

ע צ

Ayin ע looks like Tsadi צ, on day 14. Ayin has no flat base.

Read it

בְּרִית עוֹלָם

בְּ רִי ת עוֹ לָ ם

be ri t o la m

“an everlasting covenant” *Genesis 9:16*

God’s promise to Noah after the Flood. It comes with a sign in the cloud. You’ll read it on day 17.

Tomorrow *What Abraham answers when God calls him.*



Nun

n, as in *no*. At the end of a word it drops below the line: ן.

ן ו

Final Nun ן drops below the line. Vav ו stays on it.

Read it

הִנֵּנִי

הִ נֵּ נִי

hi ne ni

“here I am” *Genesis 22:1*

God calls Abraham, and this is his answer. He answers the angel the same way in verse 11.

ח Het

kh, a raspy h from the back of the throat.

ח ה Het ח is closed at the top. He ה has a gap.

Read it

חֵן

ן חֵ

n khe

“grace, favor” *Genesis 6:8*

God decides to wipe out mankind. Then one line: “But Noah found grace.”

Tomorrow *A tree, and the cherubim who guard the way to it.*



Tsadi

ts, as in *cats*. At the end of a word it drops down: ץ.

צ ע Tsadi צ has a flat base. Ayin ע does not.

Read it

עֵץ הַחַיִּים

עֵ ץ הַ חַ יִּ ם

e ts ha kha yi m

“the tree of life” *Genesis 3:24*

It stands in the middle of the garden (Genesis 2:9). After the man is sent out, cherubim guard the way to it.



Gimel

g, as in *go*.

◌ְ	Three dots: **e**, as in *bed*.
וּ־ע	A short line at the top links two words. It has no sound.
ג ג נ	Gimel ג has a small foot. Nun נ sits flat on the line.

Read it

בְּגַן־עֵדֶן

ן	דֶ	עֵ	ן	גַ	בְּ
n	de	e	n	ga	ve

“in the garden of Eden” *Genesis 2:15*

The man is placed there to work it and to keep it.

Review: read these without the sound row

טוֹב מְאֹד · שָׁלוֹם · בְּרִית עוֹלָם ·

הִנֵּנִי · חֵן · עֵץ הַחַיִּים

Tomorrow *What Abram is told to be.*

כ ך

Kaf

With a dot: **k**, as in *king*.
Without it: **kh**, like Het. At the end of a word it drops down: ך.

ב כ

Bet ב has a small foot at the bottom right. Kaf כ is round, with no foot.

Read it

בְּרָכָה

ה כָ ָ רָ ָ בְּ

silent kha ra be

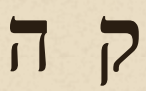
“a blessing” *Genesis 12:2*

God tells Abram to leave his father’s house. Verse 2 ends: “…and be a blessing.”



Qof

k, as in *king*. The same sound as כ.



Qof ק has a leg that drops below the line. He ה stays on it.

Read it

הַקֶּשֶׁת

ת שֶׁ קֶ הַ

t she ke ha

“the rainbow” *Genesis 9:14*

After the Flood: “the bow will be seen in the cloud.”

Tomorrow *What the first man becomes when God breathes into him.*



Pe

With a dot: **p**, as in *pen*.
Without it: **f**, as in *fish*. At the end of a word: ף.



At the front of a word, לְ often means **to** or **into**.

Read it

לְנֶפֶשׁ חַיָּה

ה	יָ	חַ	שׁ	פֶ	נֶ	לְ
silent	ya	kha	sh	fe	ne	le

“into a living soul” *Genesis 2:7*

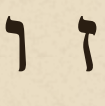
God forms the man from the dust and breathes into him, and the man becomes a living soul.

Tomorrow *The first word of the Sabbath commandment in Exodus.*



Zayin

z, as in *zoo*.



The top of Zayin ז sticks out on both sides. The top of Vav ו only to the left.

Read it

זָכוֹר

זָ כו ר

za kho r

“remember” *Exodus 20:8*

“Remember the Sabbath day, to keep it holy.”

Tomorrow *A word for faithful love.*



Samekh

s, as in *sun*. The same sound as שׂ.



Samekh ס is round. Final Mem ם is square.

Read it





d se khe

“faithful love, kindness” *Exodus 20:6*

In the Ten Commandments: “showing faithful love to thousands.” That was the last of the 22 letters.

No new letter. Four small marks, then a famous line.

וְ	Vav with no dot on top or inside says **v**. At the front of a word, וְ or וַ means **and**.
הַבְּ	In the middle of a word, two stacked dots are usually silent, as under בְּ here.
עַ	Two dots and a line: a short **a**.
הָ	The small T inside a final ך is its vowel: הָ says **kha**.

וְאָהַבְתָּ לְרֵעֲךָ כָּמוֹךָ

“Love your neighbor as yourself.” *Leviticus 19:18*

Start at the top right. Words and sound rows both read right to left.

וְאָהַבְתָּ	לְרֵעֲךָ	כָּמוֹךָ
and you shall love	*your neighbor*	*as yourself*
וְ אָ הַ בְּ תָּ	לְ רֵ עֲ הָ	כָּ מוֹ הָ
ta v ha a ve	kha a re le	kha mo ka

Tomorrow *A whole verse about Jacob and Rachel.*

Read a whole verse.

No new letters today. Four last notes, then the verse.

נָיו	A י with no vowel of its own, right after a vowel, is silent: עֵי is **e**, and נָיו is **nav**.
וּן	Vav with a dot in the middle: **u**, as in *flute*.
תָה	A ה with a dot inside, at the end of a word, is said: תָה is **tah**.
בְּ	You've seen בְּ mean **in**. Here it means **for**: seven years for Rachel.

וַיַּעֲבֹד יַעֲקֹב בְּרָחֵל שֶׁבַע שָׁנִים
וַיִּהְיוּ בְעֵינָיו כְּיָמִים אֲחָדִים
בְּאַהֲבָתוֹ אֹתָהּ

"Jacob served seven years for Rachel, and they seemed to him like a few days, because he loved her." Genesis 29:20

Stuck? *The next page takes it word by word.*

Word by word.

Start at the top right. Words and sound rows both read right to left.

וַיַּעֲבֹד
and he served
וַ יַ עֲ בֹ ד
d vo a ya va

יַעֲקֹב
Jacob
יַ עֲ קֹ ב
v ko a ya

בְּרָחֵל
for Rachel
בְּ רָ חֵ ל
l khe ra be

שֶׁבַע
seven
שֶׁ בַ ע
silent va she

שָׁנִים
years
שָׁ נִ ים
m ni sha

וַיִּהְיוּ
and they were
וַ יִּ הְ יוּ
yu h yi va

בְּעֵינָיו
in his eyes
בְּ עֵ ינָ יו
nav e ve

כְּיָמִים
like days
כְּ יָ מִ ים
m mi ya ke

אֲחָדִים
a few
אֲ חָ דִ ים
m di kha a

בְּאַהֲבָתוֹ
in his love
בְּ אַ הֲ בָ תוֹ
to va ha a be

אֹתָהּ
her
אֹ תָ הּ
tah o

Seven years felt like a few days.

Next page *Watch where their story began.*

בְּאַהֲבָתוֹ אֹתָהּ

“because he loved her”

You just read a verse of Genesis in Hebrew.

Watch how it began

Why Everyone in the Bible Meets Their Wife at a Well

This Thursday

Look for Ink of Sinai in your inbox: this week’s Torah reading, plus a summary of the week’s insights.

Tell us

Hit reply to our next email and name the letter that was hardest.